

Meridian Harbor Technologies, Inc.

IT and Information Security Handbook — 2026 Edition

Applies to all employees, contractors, interns, and temporary workers of Meridian Harbor Technologies, Inc. ("Meridian Harbor", "MHT", or "the Company").

Internal Use Only

Fictional source document prepared for the HR/IT Knowledge Base Copilot project.

1. Introduction and Purpose
2. IT Service Desk
3. Corporate Password Policy
4. Password Reset Procedure
5. VPN Access and VPN Troubleshooting
6. Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)
7. Company Devices and Laptops
8. Software Installation Rules
9. Internet and Network Usage
10. Remote Working Security
11. Phishing and Email Security
12. Data Protection and Confidential Information
13. Lost or Stolen Devices
14. IT Incident Reporting
15. Account Lockout and Access Issues
16. Employee Responsibilities
17. IT Support and Escalation Process
18. Exceptions
19. Document Information

1. Introduction and Purpose

1.1 Purpose

This handbook sets out the rules, procedures, and support options for using Meridian Harbor's technology and protecting its information. It exists to:

- Protect the confidentiality, integrity, and availability of Company, customer, and partner data.
- Give employees clear, practical answers to everyday IT questions.
- Meet our contractual and regulatory obligations (including SOC 2 Type II, ISO/IEC 27001, GDPR, and customer security agreements).

1.2 Scope

This handbook applies to:

- All Company-owned devices (laptops, desktops, tablets, phones, peripherals, hardware security keys).
- All Company systems, applications, cloud services, networks, and accounts.
- Personal devices that are enrolled in Company mobile device management (MDM) for email or collaboration access.
- Anyone working from a Meridian Harbor office (Boston, MA headquarters; Austin, TX; Dublin, Ireland) or remotely.

1.3 Key Systems and Terms

Term	Meaning
HarborDesk	The IT ticketing and service portal (help.meridianharbor.example)
HarborID	The Company's single sign-on (SSO) and identity system
HarborConnect	The Company's VPN client
Harbor Authenticator	The approved MFA mobile app
HarborKey	The Company-issued FIDO2 hardware security key
HarborVault	The approved enterprise password manager
HarborShield	The endpoint detection and response (EDR) agent installed on all Company devices
HarborMDM	The mobile device management platform
SOC	The Security Operations Center, which monitors for threats 24/7

1.4 Policy Hierarchy

If this handbook conflicts with a law or regulation, the law prevails. If it conflicts with a signed customer contract requiring stricter controls, the stricter requirement prevails. Violations may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination, and where applicable, legal action.

2. IT Service Desk

2.1 Hours of Operation

Service	Hours
Standard support (phone, chat, portal)	Monday–Friday, 7:00 AM – 7:00 PM Eastern Time (excluding Company holidays)
Security emergency hotline	24 hours a day, 7 days a week, 365 days a year
Dublin office on-site desk	Monday–Friday, 8:30 AM – 5:30 PM Irish time
After-hours critical outages (P1)	24/7 via the hotline

2.2 How to Contact the Service Desk

Channel	Details	Best for
HarborDesk portal	help.meridianharbor.example	Non-urgent requests, access requests, tracking tickets
Phone	1-800-555-0142 (option 1 = Service Desk, option 2 = Security Hotline)	Urgent issues, lockouts, lost devices
Email	helpdesk@meridianharbor.example	Simple questions, attaching screenshots
Slack	#it-help	Quick questions (no personal or sensitive data in this channel)
Security reports	security@meridianharbor.example	Phishing, suspected compromise
Walk-up	Boston 4th floor "Tech Bar" (9:00 AM – 4:00 PM), Austin Suite 210, Dublin Level 2	Hardware swaps, peripherals, in-person help

2.3 What the Service Desk Handles

- Password resets, account unlocks, and MFA recovery
- VPN, Wi-Fi, and connectivity problems
- Laptop, phone, and peripheral issues
- Software requests and installations
- New hire setup and employee offboarding
- Access requests to applications and shared drives
- Reporting of security concerns

2.4 Ticket Priorities and Targets

Priority	Definition	Examples	First response	Target resolution
P1 – Critical	Company-wide or major customer-impacting outage, or confirmed security incident	Email down for all users, ransomware, confirmed data breach	15 minutes	4 hours
P2 – High	A single user or team cannot work at all, no workaround	Locked-out account before a customer meeting, laptop will not boot	1 hour	1 business day
P3 – Medium	Work is impaired but a workaround exists	Slow VPN, printer issues, app crashes occasionally	4 business hours	3 business days
P4 – Low	Requests and minor issues	New monitor, software request, how-to question	1 business day	5 business days

2.5 Before You Contact the Service Desk

Please have the following ready to speed up resolution:

1. Your name, employee ID, and office or remote location
2. Your laptop asset tag (a white label on the bottom of the device, format MHT-XXXXXX)
3. A description of what you were doing and the exact error message (a screenshot helps)
4. When the problem started and what you have already tried

2.6 Identity Verification

The Service Desk will never perform a password reset, MFA reset, or access change without first verifying your identity (see Section 4.3). Agents will never ask for your current password or MFA codes. If someone asks for these, hang up and report it to security@meridianharbor.example.

3. Corporate Password Policy

3.1 Password Requirements

All passwords for Company accounts must meet the following standards:

Requirement	Standard accounts	Privileged / admin accounts
Minimum length	14 characters	20 characters
Complexity	Must include at least 3 of 4: uppercase, lowercase, number, symbol	Same, plus must be generated by HarborVault
Maximum age	180 days	90 days
Password history	Cannot reuse your last 12 passwords	Last 24
Minimum age	1 day (cannot change more than once per 24 hours)	1 day
Expiry reminders	Emails at 14, 7, 3, and 1 day before expiry	Same

Passphrases are encouraged. Example of a strong passphrase: Harbor-Lantern-Quilt-47-Tidepool (a string of unrelated words plus numbers and separators).

3.2 Prohibited Passwords

Passwords must not:

- Contain your name, username, employee ID, or the words "Meridian", "Harbor", or "MHT"
- Include seasons or years in predictable patterns (e.g., Summer2026!)
- Be on the commonly breached password list that HarborID checks automatically
- Be reused from any personal account or any other Company system
- Be a simple keyboard pattern (qwerty12345678)

3.3 Account Lockout Thresholds

- **5 consecutive failed sign-in attempts within 15 minutes** locks the account.
- The lock automatically clears after **30 minutes**, or sooner if you unlock it via self-service (Section 4) or contact the Service Desk.
- Privileged accounts lock after **3 failed attempts** and require manual unlock by the Service Desk.

3.4 Password Storage and Sharing

- **Never** write passwords on paper, sticky notes, or unencrypted files.
- **Never** share your password with anyone, including your manager, IT staff, or colleagues. IT will never need it.
- Use **HarborVault** to store work-related passwords. Each employee receives a licensed account on day one.
- Do not save Company passwords in web browsers' built-in password managers.
- Shared service accounts must be stored in HarborVault shared folders approved by IT Security, and cannot be used for interactive login by individuals.

3.5 Compromised Passwords

If you suspect a password has been exposed (for example, you entered it on a suspicious page), change it immediately and report to security@meridianharbor.example within **1 hour** (see Section 14).

4. Password Reset Procedure

4.1 Self-Service Reset (Fastest Option)

Use this method if you can still access your registered MFA method.

1. Go to **reset.meridianharbor.example** from any device.
2. Enter your Company email address.
3. Approve the MFA prompt in Harbor Authenticator (or tap your HarborKey).
4. Enter a new password that meets Section 3.1 requirements.
5. Confirm. Your new password takes effect within 2 minutes across all systems.
6. Sign out of any active sessions and sign in again. On your laptop, lock and unlock the screen while connected to the corporate network or VPN so your cached credentials update.

Limits: Self-service allows **3 resets per 24 hours**. After that, contact the Service Desk.

4.2 Resetting a Password When You Are Locked Out of MFA

If you cannot approve MFA, self-service will not work. Follow Section 6.6 (MFA recovery) first, or call the Service Desk.

4.3 Service Desk-Assisted Reset

1. Call 1-800-555-0142 (option 1) or open a chat from the HarborDesk portal.
2. The agent will verify your identity using **at least two** of the following:
 - Employee ID and date of hire
 - Your manager's name and department cost center
 - A callback to your phone number on file in the HR system

- A short video call showing your Company badge (required if you are remote and contacting from an unrecognized phone number)
- 3. The agent issues a **temporary password**, delivered by a method matching your verification (text message to the number on file, or read aloud on the verified call).
- 4. The temporary password is valid for **4 hours** and must be changed at your next sign-in.
- 5. Choose a new password that meets Section 3.1.

4.4 Troubleshooting Forgotten or Non-Working Passwords

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
"Incorrect username or password" after resetting	Old password cached on a device, phone, or mail app	Update the saved password on your phone (Mail, Slack, Teams) and any other device. Outdated cached passwords are the #1 cause of repeated lockouts.
Password accepted on web but not on laptop	Laptop has not synced the new password	Connect to the VPN or office network, lock the screen (Win+L / Ctrl+Cmd+Q), and sign in again with the new password. Reboot if it still fails.
"Password does not meet requirements"	Reuse of last 12 passwords, or on the breached list	Pick a new passphrase of 14+ characters and avoid anything resembling a previous password.
"You cannot change your password yet"	You changed it less than 24 hours ago	Wait 24 hours or ask the Service Desk to override.
Reset link/email never arrives	Mail filtering, or typing the wrong address	Check spam, confirm you used your @meridianharbor.example address, and wait 5 minutes. If you still do not get it, use the Service Desk.
Account locked after reset	An old password is still being sent from a phone or app	Remove and re-add your work account on all devices, then unlock (Section 15).
Cannot sign in on a brand-new laptop	Not yet connected to the network or VPN	Connect to Wi-Fi first; at the sign-in screen choose "Other user" and sign in once on the network so your credentials sync.

4.5 Password Expiry Behavior

- Expiry notices are emailed starting 14 days before the deadline.
- If your password expires while you are traveling or working remotely, you can change it with Ctrl+Alt+Delete → *Change a password* (Windows) or *System Settings* → *Users & Groups* → *Change Password* (macOS) while connected to the VPN.
- Expired passwords do not delete data; they simply prevent sign-in until updated.

5. VPN Access and VPN Troubleshooting

5.1 When You Must Use the VPN

You **must** connect to HarborConnect when:

- Accessing internal systems (file shares, intranet, source repositories, internal dashboards) from any location outside a Meridian Harbor office
- Using public or untrusted Wi-Fi (airports, hotels, cafes, coworking spaces)
- Accessing any system classified Confidential or Restricted (see Section 12)

Cloud applications protected by HarborID and MFA (Email, Slack, Google Workspace, Salesforce) do not require the VPN from a home network, but we recommend staying connected anyway.

5.2 VPN Access and Setup

- HarborConnect is pre-installed on all Company laptops. Do not install any other VPN client.
- Sign in with your HarborID username and approve the MFA prompt.
- Available gateways: **vpn-east.meridianharbor.example** (US East), **vpn-west.meridianharbor.example** (US West), **vpn-eu.meridianharbor.example** (Europe). Leave the gateway on **Auto** unless instructed by IT.
- Contractors receive VPN access only if their manager requests it through HarborDesk and the request is approved (2 business days).

5.3 VPN Rules

Rule	Value
Maximum session length	12 hours , then you must reconnect and re-authenticate
Idle timeout	30 minutes of inactivity
Tunnel mode	Full tunnel (all traffic routed through Meridian Harbor)
Simultaneous connections	1 per user
Company laptops only	Personal computers may not connect to the VPN
Streaming/personal downloads	Discouraged over VPN; may be throttled
Disconnecting	Never disable the VPN or the client's always-on setting on public networks

5.4 Step-by-Step Connection

1. Connect to the internet (home Wi-Fi, hotspot, hotel network).
2. Open **HarborConnect** from your system tray (Windows) or menu bar (macOS).
3. Leave the gateway as **Auto** and click **Connect**.
4. Enter your HarborID password if asked, then approve the MFA push (match the number shown).
5. Wait for the green "Connected" status.

5.5 VPN Troubleshooting Guide

Quick Fixes to Try First (resolves ~70% of issues)

1. Confirm your internet works (open any public website).
2. Quit and reopen HarborConnect.
3. Restart your laptop.
4. Switch networks (try a phone hotspot) to rule out a router or ISP block.
5. Make sure your system date and time are set to automatic. A clock that is off by more than 5 minutes breaks MFA and certificate checks.

Common Errors

Error / symptom	Cause	Fix
HC-101: Unable to reach gateway	No internet, or firewall blocking the connection	Test your internet. Try another network or a phone hotspot. Some hotel and airport networks require you to accept terms in a browser first — open any website, accept, then reconnect.
HC-201: Authentication failed	Wrong password, or password recently changed	Re-enter your password. If you recently changed it, update the saved credentials in the client (<i>Settings</i> → <i>Sign out</i> → <i>Sign in</i>). After 5 failures your account locks (Section 15).
HC-202: MFA timed out / not approved	Push notification missed or phone offline	Make sure your phone has internet access, open Harbor Authenticator, and retry. Prompts expire after 60 seconds . If you do not receive pushes, use the 6-digit code option, or see Section 6.7.
HC-301: Certificate invalid or expired	Laptop's device certificate is out of date, or the clock is wrong	Set date/time to automatic and restart. If it persists, open a P2 ticket — IT will re-issue your device certificate remotely, usually within 1 hour.
HC-401: Device not compliant	Laptop failed a security health check (outdated OS, disk encryption off, HarborShield not running)	Install pending updates and restart. Confirm HarborShield is running. If you cannot fix it, open a ticket with your asset tag.
HC-501: Session limit reached	Already connected on another device	Disconnect the other session. Only one connection is allowed.
Connected but cannot reach internal sites	DNS issue or split-DNS conflict	Disconnect, run <code>ipconfig /flushdns</code> (Windows) or <code>sudo dscacheutil -flushcache</code> (macOS), reconnect. Try accessing by full hostname, e.g. <code>intranet.meridianharbor.example</code> .
VPN is very slow	Congested gateway, weak Wi-Fi, or bandwidth-heavy apps	Move closer to the router or use an Ethernet cable. Close video streaming or large cloud syncs. Try manually selecting a closer gateway. Open a P3 ticket if slowness persists over 24 hours.
VPN disconnects every few minutes	Unstable Wi-Fi, or power-saving mode	Disable Wi-Fi power-saving, use 5 GHz Wi-Fi, or connect via Ethernet. Update HarborConnect via the Software Portal.

Error / symptom	Cause	Fix
Works on phone hotspot but not home Wi-Fi	Home router or ISP is blocking VPN traffic	Restart your router. Disable "VPN passthrough blocking" or any parental/security filtering. If unresolved, keep using the hotspot and open a P3 ticket.
Works at home but not abroad	Some countries restrict VPN traffic	Contact IT <i>before</i> travel (see Section 10.6).

Escalate to IT When

- You have tried the quick fixes and cannot connect within 15 minutes and have a deadline: call the Service Desk (P2).
- You receive an error not listed above: send a screenshot and the time to helpdesk@meridianharbor.example.
- You see repeated unexpected VPN MFA prompts you did not initiate: treat this as a possible attack and follow Section 6.8.

6. Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)

6.1 Requirement

MFA is **mandatory** for all Meridian Harbor accounts, with no exceptions for seniority. MFA protects you even if your password is stolen.

6.2 Approved MFA Methods

Method	Description	Allowed for
Harbor Authenticator push (with number matching)	Approve a login on your phone by entering the 2-digit number shown on screen	All employees (default)
Harbor Authenticator one-time code	6-digit code refreshed every 30 seconds	Use when push is unavailable
HarborKey (FIDO2 hardware key)	Tap-to-authenticate USB-C/NFC key	Required for administrators, finance approvers, and users with Restricted data access; optional for others
Backup codes	10 single-use codes generated at enrollment	Emergency use only; store in HarborVault
SMS / voice call	Text or call to your phone	Not permitted as a standard method; only as a temporary Service Desk-issued fallback for up to 24 hours

6.3 Enrollment

1. On your first day, visit aka.meridianharbor.example/mfa from your Company laptop.
2. Install **Harbor Authenticator** (iOS/Android) from the official app store.
3. Scan the QR code and approve the test push.
4. Register a second method (HarborKey or backup codes) — **at least two methods** are required.

5. Save backup codes in HarborVault, not in email or on your desktop.

6.4 How Often You Will Be Prompted

Scenario	Frequency
Company laptop, on trusted network	Once every 12 hours
New or unrecognized device	Every sign-in
VPN connection	Every connection
Sensitive apps (finance, HR, production admin)	Every 60 minutes (step-up authentication)
Public/untrusted network	Every sign-in

6.5 Changing Phones or Devices

Before you give up your old phone:

1. Open **aka.meridianharbor.example/mfa** and add your new phone as a second method.
2. Confirm the new phone works by approving a test push.
3. Remove the old device.

If you do this before switching, no help desk contact is needed. If you wipe your old phone first, follow Section 6.6.

6.6 MFA Recovery: Lost, Replaced, or Broken Phone

1. Try your **backup methods first**: HarborKey, backup codes, or a second registered device.
2. If none work, call the Service Desk (1-800-555-0142, option 1) and request an **MFA reset**.
3. The agent will verify your identity using the video-call process in Section 4.3 (two forms of verification plus a visible badge). Verification by email or chat alone is not accepted.
4. The agent will:
 - Issue a **Temporary Access Pass** valid for **8 hours** (one-time use per sign-in).
 - Remove the old authenticator registration.
5. Use the pass to sign in and enroll your new device immediately. Generate new backup codes.
6. Your manager is notified automatically of every MFA reset.

Timeline: MFA resets are completed within 30 minutes during support hours. MFA resets will **not** be performed by email request alone.

6.7 Troubleshooting Common MFA Problems

Problem	Cause	Fix
No push notification arrives	Phone has no data, battery saver or Do Not Disturb blocks notifications, or notification permission off	Check internet connection, turn off battery saver, allow notifications for Harbor Authenticator, open the app manually, and approve from inside the app. Alternatively choose "Use a code instead".
Code from the app is rejected	Phone clock is out of sync	iOS: <i>Settings</i> → <i>General</i> → <i>Date & Time</i> → <i>Set Automatically</i> . Android: <i>Settings</i> → <i>Date & Time</i> → <i>Automatic</i> . In the Harbor Authenticator app, use <i>Settings</i> → <i>Time correction</i> if available.
"Number does not match"	You tapped the wrong number	Cancel and retry, entering the number exactly as displayed.
App was deleted or phone reset	Registration lost	Use backup methods or follow Section 6.6.
HarborKey not recognized	Loose connection or wrong port	Try another USB-C port, remove any adapter, hold the key's touch point until it blinks, and use Chrome/Edge/Safari. Contact IT for a replacement if the key is damaged (replaced within 2 business days).
Travelling abroad with no data or roaming	Push requires internet	Use the 6-digit code option (works offline) or connect to Wi-Fi. Set this up before travel.
MFA prompt appears when you did not sign in	Possible attack	See 6.8 — do NOT approve.

6.8 MFA Fatigue and Unexpected Prompts

Attackers sometimes spam MFA prompts hoping you will approve out of annoyance.

- **Never approve a prompt you did not initiate.** Always deny.
- If you receive **more than 2 unexpected prompts**, deny them and report to security@meridianharbor.example or the Security Hotline **within 15 minutes**.
- IT will reset your password and revoke active sessions immediately. Reporting promptly will never lead to discipline.
- **Never** share your 6-digit code or backup code with anyone, even someone claiming to be IT.

7. Company Devices and Laptops

7.1 Standard Equipment

Role	Laptop	Additional
Standard employees	Dell Latitude 7450 (Windows 11) or MacBook Air 15" (macOS)	Docking station, headset
Engineers and data staff	MacBook Pro 16" or Dell Precision 5690	Second monitor on request
Executives and high-risk roles	Same as above, plus HarborKey	Privacy screen
Contractors	Loaner device or personal device via virtual desktop	Access limited to required systems

Each employee is issued **one** primary laptop. Laptops are refreshed every **3 years** (36 months), or sooner if hardware fails.

7.2 Mandatory Security Configuration

Every Company device must always have:

- **Full-disk encryption** enabled (BitLocker on Windows, FileVault on macOS)
- **HarborShield** (EDR) running; never disable or remove it
- **Automatic screen lock** after **10 minutes** of inactivity; lock manually (Win+L or Ctrl+Cmd+Q) any time you step away
- **A sign-in password** and (where available) biometrics such as Windows Hello or Touch ID
- **Firewall enabled**
- **Automatic updates** enabled

7.3 Patching and Updates

Update type	Deadline
Critical security patches	Installed within 72 hours of release
Standard OS and application updates	Within 14 days
Reboot after update prompt	Within 3 days (devices are forced to restart after 3 postponements)

Devices more than **30 days** behind on patches may be blocked from the VPN and corporate apps until updated.

7.4 Acceptable Use

- Company devices are for business use. **Limited, reasonable personal use** is permitted if it does not interfere with work, violate policy, or create security risk (e.g., checking personal banking is fine; gaming, torrenting, or running a side business is not).
- Do not allow family members, friends, or children to use your Company device.
- Do not leave devices unattended in cars, airport lounges, hotel rooms, or on public transport.
- When traveling by air, carry your laptop as hand baggage — never in checked luggage.

- Do not connect unknown USB drives, chargers, or accessories. **USB mass storage is blocked by default** on Company laptops (Section 12.6).
- Do not modify hardware or open the case.

7.5 Mobile Phones and Tablets

- Company-owned phones are enrolled in **HarborMDM** with a 6-digit PIN minimum, device encryption, and remote wipe capability.
- Personal phones (BYOD) may access Company email and Slack only if enrolled in HarborMDM's work profile, which separates Company data from personal data. IT can wipe **only the work profile** — never your photos or personal apps.
- Rooted or jailbroken devices are blocked from accessing Company systems.

7.6 Hardware Requests, Repairs, and Returns

Need	Process	Timeline
New or replacement laptop (hardware failure)	HarborDesk ticket, P2 if you cannot work	Loaner same day if in-office; 2 business days shipped
Accessories (mouse, keyboard, monitor)	HarborDesk request, manager approval for items over \$150	5 business days
Damaged device (accident)	Report within 24 hours	First incident free; repeated damage reviewed by management
Leaving the Company	Return all equipment within 5 business days of last working day	Prepaid shipping kit provided for remote employees

7.7 Troubleshooting Common Device Problems

Problem	Try this
Laptop is slow	Restart, close unused apps and browser tabs, check storage (keep at least 15% free), confirm updates are not stuck. Open a P3 ticket if it persists after a reboot.
Laptop will not turn on	Hold the power button for 15 seconds, connect the original charger for 30 minutes, then retry. If still dead, open a P2 ticket and bring it to the Tech Bar.
Wi-Fi not working	Toggle Wi-Fi off/on, forget and rejoin the network, restart. See Section 9.
Screen flickering or black	Reconnect the dock/cable, try a different port, restart.
Blue screen / kernel panic	Note the error code, restart. If it recurs, open a P2 ticket — do not attempt repairs.
Battery drains fast	Lower screen brightness, close heavy apps, check for pending updates. Batteries below 70% health are replaced free of charge.
Webcam or microphone not working	Check app permissions and that Teams/Zoom has the right device selected; restart.

8. Software Installation Rules

8.1 Core Rule

Only software that appears in the **Meridian Harbor Software Portal** (or has been approved via ticket) may be installed on Company devices. Standard users do **not** have administrator rights.

8.2 Installing Approved Software

1. Open the **Software Portal** (Windows: *Company Portal*; macOS: *Harbor Self Service*).
2. Search for the application.
3. Click **Install**. Most installs finish within 10 minutes.

Pre-approved software includes: Microsoft 365, Google Workspace, Slack, Zoom, Microsoft Teams, Adobe Acrobat Reader, Chrome, Firefox, Visual Studio Code, Docker Desktop, Git, Postman, 7-Zip, Notion, Figma, and HarborVault.

8.3 Requesting New Software

1. Open a **HarborDesk** request under *Software* → *New Software Request*.
2. Provide: software name and version, business justification, cost, number of users, and whether it will handle Company or customer data.
3. Your manager approves the business need.
4. IT reviews the request.

Request type	Review time
Software already licensed and security-approved	3 business days
New software (low risk, no Company data)	5 business days
New vendor or cloud service handling Company/customer data	10 business days (security and privacy review, vendor risk assessment)
Software requiring a purchase over \$5,000	Additional finance approval; 15 business days

8.4 Prohibited Software

The following may **not** be installed or used on Company devices or to process Company data:

- Peer-to-peer or torrent clients
- Unlicensed, cracked, or pirated software
- Cryptocurrency mining software
- Remote-access tools not provided by IT (AnyDesk, TeamViewer, etc.), unless installed by IT
- Personal VPNs, proxy, or tunneling tools
- Hacking, password-cracking, or network-scanning tools, except on approval for authorized Security Team members
- Free "PDF converters", browser extensions from unknown publishers, or screen recorders from untrusted sources
- Personal cloud storage sync clients (Dropbox personal, personal Google Drive, iCloud Drive for Company files)

8.5 Generative AI and Online Tools

- You may use only **Company-approved AI tools** (currently: **Claude for Enterprise** and **GitHub Copilot Business**) with Company information.

- **Never** enter Confidential or Restricted data (customer personal data, source code from restricted repositories, financial results before release, credentials, or contracts) into non-approved AI tools, translation sites, or online converters.
- You remain responsible for reviewing AI-generated work before use.

8.6 Browser Extensions

Only extensions on the approved list (managed via Chrome Enterprise) may be used. Others are blocked automatically. Request an addition through HarborDesk (5 business days).

8.7 Open Source and Development Tools

Engineers may use open source libraries following the Secure Development Standard: dependencies are scanned for vulnerabilities, licenses reviewed (GPL/AGPL require Legal approval), and no packages are pulled from untrusted registries.

8.8 Consequences

Unauthorized software is automatically detected by HarborShield and may be removed without notice. Repeated or deliberate violations are reported to your manager and HR.

9. Internet and Network Usage

9.1 Corporate Wi-Fi

Network	Purpose	Who can connect	Authentication
MHT-Secure	Corporate network	Company laptops/phones	Automatic via device certificate (802.1X)
MHT-Guest	Visitors	Guests, personal devices	Password changes weekly; sponsor registration required; internet only
MHT-Lab	Test/dev (restricted)	Approved engineers	Separate approval

Personal devices must **never** connect to MHT-Secure. Guests must be registered at reception before receiving the guest password; guest access expires after **24 hours**.

9.2 Acceptable Internet Use

- Internet access is provided for business use. Reasonable personal browsing is allowed during breaks.
- Web filtering automatically blocks malicious sites, adult content, gambling, illegal downloads, and known phishing domains.
- Do not use Company bandwidth for high-volume streaming, large personal downloads, or video games.
- Do not attempt to bypass web filters, proxies, or firewalls. This is a policy violation and is logged.

9.3 Prohibited Online Activities

- Accessing or sharing illegal, harassing, discriminatory, or sexually explicit content
- Downloading or sharing copyrighted material without permission
- Sending confidential information through personal email, personal messaging apps (WhatsApp, Telegram, WeChat), or personal social media accounts
- Posting Company information, screenshots of internal systems, or customer details on social media or forums

9.4 Monitoring and Privacy

Meridian Harbor monitors network traffic, web usage, email metadata, and device activity on Company systems for security, compliance, and performance. Monitoring is performed by authorized IT Security staff only, in accordance with local law. **Do not expect personal privacy on Company systems.**

9.5 Public and Hotel Wi-Fi

- Always connect to the VPN **before** using any sensitive application.
- Verify the network name with the venue (attackers create fake networks with similar names).
- Prefer your phone's mobile hotspot where possible. Hotspot use is reimbursable for business travel.
- Turn off file sharing and AirDrop (set to "Contacts Only" or "Off").

9.6 Network Troubleshooting

Issue	Steps
Cannot connect to MHT-Secure	Toggle Wi-Fi, forget the network, restart. If it still fails, your device certificate may have expired — open a P3 ticket.
Connected but "No internet"	Test with another site; restart your laptop; try Ethernet through the dock. If others near you also lose connectivity, report to #it-help.
Website blocked	You will see a "Blocked by Meridian Harbor Web Policy" page. If you need the site for work, submit a Web Access Request in HarborDesk (1 business day).
Meeting video quality is poor	Close other apps, use wired Ethernet or 5 GHz Wi-Fi, turn off your camera if bandwidth is limited.
Printer cannot be found	Connect to MHT-Secure (not guest), then add the printer via the Software Portal's <i>Printers</i> section.

10. Remote Working Security

10.1 Eligibility and Approval

Remote and hybrid work arrangements are approved by your manager and HR. Remote workers must follow all requirements in this handbook, including those below.

10.2 Home Network Requirements

- Use a **password-protected** home Wi-Fi with **WPA2-AES** or **WPA3** encryption. Open networks and WEP are not permitted.
- Change the default router administrator password and Wi-Fi password.
- Keep router firmware up to date (check every 6 months).
- Disable remote administration and WPS on your router.
- Avoid connecting smart home devices (cameras, speakers) to the same network segment as your work laptop where possible; use a guest network for them.

10.3 Physical Workspace Security

- Work from a private area. Do not discuss Confidential information where it can be overheard (including by smart speakers).
- Lock your screen whenever you leave your workspace, even at home.
- Do not leave documents containing Confidential or Restricted information visible; use a locked drawer or shred them (cross-cut shredder).
- Position your screen away from windows and shared spaces; use a privacy filter in public.
- Never let others use your Company equipment.

10.4 Technical Requirements for Remote Work

- Use only your Company laptop.
- Connect to **HarborConnect** for internal resources.
- Do not use public computers (libraries, hotel business centers) to access Company systems.
- Do not store Company data on personal devices, personal USB drives, or personal cloud accounts.
- Printing at home: print only when necessary, and shred or return documents classified Confidential or above.
- Video calls: use approved tools only (Teams, Zoom with Company account). Check your background for sensitive information before sharing your screen.

10.5 Working from Coworking Spaces, Cafes, and Public Places

- Always use the VPN.
- Never leave your laptop unattended, even for a moment.
- Use a privacy screen; avoid displaying Restricted data.
- Do not take confidential calls in public.

10.6 Working While Traveling

Scenario	Requirement
Domestic travel (within home country)	No pre-approval; follow Sections 7 and 10.5
International travel	Notify your manager and IT Security via HarborDesk at least 5 business days before departure
High-risk countries (list maintained by IT Security and updated quarterly)	Request 10 business days in advance; you will be issued a clean loaner laptop and phone with minimal data; Company devices may not be taken
Working from another country for more than 14 days	Requires written approval from HR, Legal (tax/employment), and IT Security

Before you travel: enroll at least two MFA methods that work offline (backup codes or HarborKey), confirm VPN access works, and back up your data. At borders, if asked to unlock a device or provide passwords, comply with lawful instructions, then **report to the Security Hotline immediately**.

10.7 Remote Work Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
Cannot reach internal tools	Connect to the VPN (Section 5).
Home internet is down	Use your phone hotspot (VPN still required); if neither works, notify your manager.
Printer or scanner not available at home	Use digital signatures (DocuSign) instead of printing.
Video meetings freeze	Wired connection, close heavy apps, ask others to pause streaming.

11. Phishing and Email Security

11.1 What Is Phishing?

Phishing is a fraudulent message, usually email, text (smishing), phone call (vishing), or chat message, designed to trick you into revealing credentials, clicking malicious links, opening malware, or sending money.

11.2 Warning Signs

- **Urgency or threats:** "Your account will be suspended in 2 hours."
- **Unexpected requests:** gift cards, wire transfers, changed bank details, "quick favor" from an executive.
- **Sender mismatch:** display name says "CEO", but the address is `ceo.meridianharbor@gmail.com` or `m3ridianharbor.com` (lookalike domains).
- **Suspicious links:** hover over a link to see the real address; look for misspellings or odd domains.
- **Unexpected attachments:** especially `.zip`, `.html`, `.iso`, `.exe`, `.js`, or Office files asking you to "enable macros".
- **Generic greetings** or poor spelling and grammar (though modern phishing may be well written).
- **Requests to move the conversation** to WhatsApp, Telegram, or personal email.
- **QR codes** in emails ("quishing") or messages asking you to scan to "verify" your account.

11.3 Email Protections

- External emails show a yellow **[EXTERNAL]** banner.
- Attachments of types `.exe`, `.scr`, `.bat`, `.js`, `.iso`, and password-protected `.zip` are blocked.
- Links are rewritten and scanned at the time you click them.
- Automatic email authentication (SPF, DKIM, DMARC) is enforced for `meridianharbor.example`.

11.4 What to Do With a Suspicious Email

1. **Do not** click links, open attachments, or reply.
2. Click the **"Report Phish"** button in Outlook/Gmail (top toolbar). This removes the message from your inbox and sends it to the Security Team.
3. If the button is unavailable, forward the email **as an attachment to `phishing@meridianharbor.example`**.
4. Delete it afterwards.

You will receive an automated acknowledgement. The SOC reviews reports within **1 hour** during business hours and removes similar emails from all inboxes where appropriate.

11.5 If You Clicked a Link or Opened an Attachment

Act within 15 minutes. Quick action prevents most damage.

1. **Disconnect** from Wi-Fi/Ethernet (do not shut down the laptop).
2. **Call the Security Hotline: 1-800-555-0142, option 2** (24/7).
3. If you entered a password, change it from another trusted device using reset.meridianharbor.example.
4. Do not delete the email or try to clean the device yourself.
5. The SOC will isolate your device, reset credentials, revoke sessions, and investigate. You will not be penalized for reporting honestly and promptly.

11.6 Business Email Compromise (BEC) and Payment Fraud

- **Any change to vendor bank details or urgent payment request must be verified by phone** using a number from our vendor records — never a number in the email.
- Wire transfers over **\$10,000** require approval from two authorized finance staff.
- Executives will never ask you to buy gift cards or keep a transaction secret.
- If unsure, ask: *"Did I expect this? Can I verify it another way?"*

11.7 Phishing Training and Simulations

Activity	Requirement
New hire security awareness training	Complete within 30 days of start date
Annual refresher training	Complete by March 31 each year
Simulated phishing campaigns	Run monthly
Clicked a simulated phish	Short 10-minute remedial training assigned within 7 days
3 or more simulation failures within 12 months	Mandatory one-on-one session, manager notified
Uncompleted mandatory training	Account access may be suspended after 14 days past the deadline

11.8 Safe Email Practices

- Verify unexpected requests, even from known colleagues, using another channel (call or Slack).
- Don't use your Company email address to sign up for personal websites or newsletters.
- Don't auto-forward Company email to personal addresses (auto-forwarding is blocked).
- Use "Confidential" sensitivity labels and encryption when sending sensitive data externally (Section 12.4).

12. Data Protection and Confidential Information

12.1 Data Classification

Level	Description	Examples
Public	Approved for public release	Marketing materials, published blog posts, job postings
Internal	Everyday business information; not for public sharing	Org charts, internal policies, meeting notes
Confidential	Sensitive business information; damage if exposed	Customer lists, contracts, pricing, financial forecasts, product roadmaps, source code
Restricted	Highest sensitivity; legal/regulatory impact if exposed	Customer personal data (PII), payment card data, health data, employee HR/salary records, encryption keys, credentials, unreleased financial results

If you are unsure, treat data as **Confidential** and ask your manager or security@meridianharbor.example.

12.2 Handling Rules by Classification

Action	Public	Internal	Confidential	Restricted
Store on Company-approved systems only	–	✓	✓	✓
Share externally	Yes	With manager approval	NDA required, use secure link	Legal/Security approval required
Email externally	Yes	Yes	Encrypted only	Not permitted without approval
Print	Yes	Yes	Yes, shred after use	Only if essential; shred immediately
Store on laptop	Yes	Yes	Yes (encrypted)	Avoid; use secure repositories
Store on USB	Yes	No	No	Never
Use non-approved AI tools	OK	No	No	Never

12.3 Where to Store Data

- Use **Google Drive (Company account)**, **SharePoint**, or approved repositories.
- Do not save Company data on personal cloud services, personal email, or local-only storage.
- Do not keep the only copy of important work on your laptop; sync folders are backed up automatically every **4 hours**.
- Source code belongs in the Company's GitHub Enterprise organization.

12.4 Sharing and Sending Data Securely

- Share links with **specific people** (named accounts), not "anyone with the link".
- Set external sharing links to expire within **30 days**.
- For Confidential data sent outside the Company, use encrypted email (apply the **Confidential** label) or the secure file transfer portal (files.meridianharbor.example).
- Verify the recipient's address before sending. Misdirected emails must be reported (Section 14).
- Never send passwords in the same message as the file they protect.

12.5 Customer and Personal Data (Privacy)

- Collect and use personal data only for approved business purposes.
- Customer data must remain in approved regions (US data in US regions, EU customer data in EU regions) unless Legal approves otherwise.
- Do not copy production customer data into test or development environments — use anonymized or synthetic data.
- Data subject requests (access, deletion) must be forwarded to **privacy@meridianharbor.example** within **1 business day**; Legal responds within the statutory deadline (30 days under GDPR).
- **Suspected personal data breaches must be reported immediately** (Section 14). Legal notifies regulators within **72 hours** where required.

12.6 Removable Media

- USB storage is blocked by default.
- Exceptions require a documented business need and approval from your director and IT Security. Approved drives are Company-issued, hardware-encrypted, and logged.
- Lost USB drives containing Company data must be reported immediately.

12.7 Data Retention and Disposal

Data type	Retention
Email	3 years, then automatic deletion (longer if under legal hold)
Slack/Teams messages	1 year
Finance and tax records	7 years
HR records	7 years after employment ends
Backups	90 days
Security logs	13 months

- Retire devices only through IT. Laptops are wiped to NIST 800-88 standards before reuse or recycling.
- Paper with Confidential or Restricted data goes in locked shred bins, not regular recycling.
- **Legal holds** override all retention rules — you will be notified by Legal and must not delete anything covered.

12.8 Backup

Critical systems are backed up daily with quarterly restore testing. Employees are responsible for saving work in synchronized or cloud folders, not just on local drives.

13. Lost or Stolen Devices

13.1 Report Immediately

If any Company device (laptop, phone, tablet, HarborKey, badge with access) or a personal device enrolled in HarborMDM is **lost, stolen, or suspected compromised**, you must report it **within 1 hour of discovering it**. Do not wait to search first.

13.2 How to Report

1. **Call the Security Hotline: 1-800-555-0142, option 2 (24/7)**. This is the fastest method.
2. Or email security@meridianharbor.example and open a **P1 ticket** (if you can safely access another device).
3. Tell the agent:
 - What was lost (device type, asset tag if known)
 - When and where you last had it
 - Whether it was locked, and whether it contained Confidential/Restricted data
 - If it was stolen, whether a police report has been filed

13.3 What IT Will Do

Step	Timeline
Acknowledge report and open an incident	Immediately
Revoke VPN access, sessions, and device certificate	Within 15 minutes
Remote lock (and attempt to locate when MDM supports)	Within 30 minutes
Reset your passwords and MFA registrations	Within 30 minutes
Remote wipe	Immediately if Restricted data was on the device, or if stolen/lost abroad; otherwise if the device is not recovered within 24 hours
Issue a loaner or replacement device	Same day (in office) or within 2 business days (shipped)
Security review of data exposure	Within 3 business days

Because laptops use full-disk encryption, the risk of data exposure is low if the device was shut down or locked. This is why encryption is mandatory.

13.4 Your Responsibilities After Reporting

- If **stolen**, file a police report within **24 hours** and send the report number to IT Security.
- Complete the Lost/Stolen Device Form in HarborDesk within **2 business days**.
- Change any personal passwords that you may have saved on the device (e.g., personal email).
- If a personal device with work profile is lost, IT will wipe only the work profile.
- If you find the device after reporting, **do not use it**. Contact IT; it must be inspected and re-imaged before reuse.

13.5 Costs and Consequences

- Reporting promptly and honestly is **never** penalized by itself.

- First loss or theft: replacement at no cost to the employee.
- Delayed reporting (over 24 hours) or negligence (e.g., leaving a laptop in a car) may result in disciplinary review.
- **Three or more losses in 24 months** triggers a mandatory manager review and additional training.

13.6 Troubleshooting Scenarios

Scenario	What to do
"I can't find my laptop; it might be in the office."	Call the Hotline anyway. IT can lock it as a precaution and unlock it later if found (usually within 30 minutes).
"I left my phone in a taxi."	Report immediately; IT will lock/wipe the work profile. Use Find My (Apple) or Find Hub (Android) to locate it, but do not try to retrieve it from strangers alone.
"My laptop was stolen while traveling abroad."	Call the Hotline immediately (international call: +1-617-555-0142), contact local police, and notify your manager. IT will wipe the device at once.
"I lost my HarborKey."	Report it. IT will deactivate it within 15 minutes. Use backup codes in the meantime; a new key arrives within 2 business days.
"My badge is missing."	Report to Facilities (facilities@meridianharbor.example) and the Security Hotline; badge is deactivated immediately. Replacement is issued same day.
"I found a USB stick or device in the office."	Do not plug it in. Hand it to the Service Desk or Security.

14. IT Incident Reporting

14.1 What Is a Security Incident?

An incident is any actual or suspected event that threatens the confidentiality, integrity, or availability of Company information or systems. Examples:

- Clicking a phishing link or entering credentials on a fake site
- Lost/stolen device (Section 13)
- Unauthorized access or unusual account activity (login alerts from unfamiliar locations)
- Malware, ransomware messages, or unexpected pop-ups
- Sending data to the wrong recipient
- Sharing a password or MFA code with someone
- Suspicious phone calls requesting information (vishing)
- Tailgating (someone entering the office without a badge)
- Discovery of exposed data (e.g., a publicly accessible document)

When in doubt, report. **Reporting does not penalize you; hiding an incident does.**

14.2 How and When to Report

Event	Report within	Channel
Suspected compromise, malware, or phishing click	15 minutes (immediately)	Security Hotline (option 2)
Lost/stolen device	1 hour	Security Hotline
Misdirected email / data sent in error	1 hour	security@meridianharbor.example
Suspicious email (not clicked)	Same business day	"Report Phish" button
Policy violations by others	As soon as possible	security@meridianharbor.example or the anonymous Ethics Line (1-800-555-0177)
Physical security issues	Immediately	Facilities and Security Hotline

14.3 What Not to Do

- Don't turn off or wipe the device unless told to (this can destroy evidence). **Disconnect from the network only.**
- Don't try to investigate or "fix" it yourself.
- Don't discuss the incident on social media or with customers or the press — refer media inquiries to Corporate Communications.
- Don't delete suspicious emails or files until the Security Team confirms they have what they need.

14.4 Incident Severity Levels

Severity	Definition	Response
Critical (P1)	Confirmed data breach, ransomware, or widespread outage	SOC engaged immediately; incident commander named within 30 minutes; executive notification within 1 hour
High (P2)	Compromised account, malware on a device, lost device with Restricted data	Response within 1 hour; contained within 4 hours
Medium (P3)	Policy violation or low-risk event with limited exposure	Response within 1 business day
Low (P4)	Security question or minor event	Response within 3 business days

14.5 What Happens After You Report

1. The SOC confirms receipt and may call you for details.
2. Affected devices are isolated and accounts secured.
3. The Security Team investigates and contains the incident.
4. Legal, Privacy, and Communications are engaged if customer data or regulatory obligations are involved. Customer notifications follow contractual timelines (typically **72 hours**) and legal requirements.
5. A post-incident review is completed within **10 business days** to prevent recurrence.

15. Account Lockout and Access Issues

15.1 Why Accounts Get Locked

- 5 failed sign-ins within 15 minutes (3 for privileged accounts)
- An old password saved on a phone, tablet, mail app, or mapped drive repeatedly retrying
- Suspicious activity detected by HarborID (e.g., sign-in from another country within minutes of your last one — "impossible travel")
- Expired password or MFA registration
- Account disabled due to inactivity or departure

15.2 Self-Service Unlock

1. Wait **30 minutes**; the account unlocks automatically.
2. Or go to **reset.meridianharbor.example** → **Unlock my account**, and approve MFA.
3. If you were locked out due to an old saved password, **remove or update it from all other devices before signing in again**, or the account will lock again.

15.3 Service Desk Unlock

Call 1-800-555-0142 (option 1) or open a P2 ticket if you cannot wait. Identity verification (Section 4.3) is required. Unlocks are completed in **15 minutes** during support hours.

15.4 Account Lockout Troubleshooting

Situation	Cause	Fix
Locked out repeatedly, every few minutes	Old password on phone, mail app, Slack, VPN, or a mapped network drive	Update/remove your account on all devices; ask IT to identify the source ("lockout source report") — available within 1 hour.
Locked out after returning from vacation	Password expired, or devices retried while you were away	Reset your password (Section 4) and update saved credentials.
"Your account has been disabled"	Inactivity (60+ days), security hold, or HR status change	Contact the Service Desk; your manager must confirm if you are an active employee.
"Your account is blocked for security reasons"	Impossible travel or compromised-credential alert	Call the Security Hotline; password and MFA will be reset after verification. This takes up to 1 hour.
Can sign in but "Access denied" to an app or folder	Missing permissions	Submit an access request (15.5).
Cannot sign in to one application only	App-specific issue, not HarborID	Clear browser cache and cookies, use a private window, try another browser, then raise a ticket naming the application.
MFA prompt loops back to sign-in	Browser cookies blocked or an old session	Clear cookies for <i>meridianharbor.example</i> , restart the browser, or try a private window.
Locked out while traveling	Time zone/network changes or lost roaming	Use backup codes; call the international line +1-617-555-0142.

15.5 Requesting Access

1. Submit a **HarborDesk Access Request** naming the system, role or permission, and business reason.
2. Your **manager** must approve (automatic reminders at 24 hours).
3. The **system owner** approves access to Confidential/Restricted systems.
4. Access is granted within **2 business days** after all approvals (standard systems) or **5 business days** (Restricted systems).

Access follows the **principle of least privilege**: you get only what your role requires. Never share accounts or use another person's credentials.

15.6 Access Reviews and Account Lifecycle

Event	Rule
New hire	Accounts created before day one; access to standard tools only
Role change	Old access removed within 5 business days ; new access requested by new manager
Quarterly access review	Managers confirm team access every quarter; unconfirmed access is removed after 14 days
Inactivity	Accounts disabled after 60 days of no sign-in; deleted after 180 days (mailbox archived)
Contractor accounts	Expire automatically on the contract end date (maximum 6 months; renewable)
Employee departure	Accounts disabled at the end of the last working day (immediately for involuntary termination); devices returned within 5 business days
Privileged access	Granted just-in-time, reviewed monthly, and expires after 8 hours

15.7 Leave of Absence

Accounts of employees on leave longer than 60 days are suspended and restored on return. Contact the Service Desk 2 days before returning.

16. Employee Responsibilities

16.1 General Responsibilities

Every person with access to Company systems must:

- Read this handbook and complete security awareness training on time (Section 11.7).
- Use Company technology and data only for authorized purposes.
- Protect their credentials and never share passwords, MFA codes, or devices.
- Keep Company devices physically secure, updated, and encrypted.
- Report incidents, lost devices, and suspicious activity within the timelines stated in Section 14.
- Follow data classification and handling rules (Section 12).
- Return all Company equipment and data when employment ends.
- Cooperate with security investigations and audits.

16.2 Manager Responsibilities

Managers must also:

- Ensure new team members complete onboarding and security training within 30 days.
- Approve access requests only if required for the role.
- Complete quarterly access reviews on time.

- Notify IT (via HarborDesk) of role changes, long leaves, and departures at least **3 business days** in advance, and immediately for involuntary departures.
- Ensure departing employees return all equipment.
- Escalate security concerns raised by their team.

16.3 IT and Security Team Responsibilities

- Provide timely support within published service levels.
- Maintain secure systems and apply patches within stated timelines.
- Monitor threats 24/7 and respond to incidents.
- Maintain this handbook and communicate updates.
- Treat employee information with confidentiality.

16.4 Contractors and Third Parties

Contractors, consultants, and vendors must sign the Acceptable Use Agreement and NDA before receiving access. Their sponsor (a Meridian Harbor manager) is accountable for their compliance.

16.5 Consequences of Non-Compliance

Violation	Typical outcome
Missed training deadline	Reminders, then access suspended after 14 days
Minor policy breach (first time)	Coaching and documented reminder
Repeated or negligent breach	Formal warning, additional training
Deliberate violation, data theft, sharing credentials, malicious activity	Termination and possible legal action
Concealing an incident	More serious than the incident itself

17. IT Support and Escalation Process

17.1 How a Ticket Moves

1. **Tier 1 – Service Desk:** Initial triage, password/MFA/account issues, standard troubleshooting. Resolves about 75% of tickets.
2. **Tier 2 – Technical Support:** Deeper endpoint, network, application, and VPN problems.
3. **Tier 3 – Engineering / Security:** Infrastructure, advanced security, and vendor issues.

Tickets are escalated automatically when they approach the SLA deadline.

17.2 Service Level Targets (Summary)

Priority	First response	Resolution target	Escalates to Tier 2	Escalates to management
P1	15 minutes	4 hours	Immediately	After 1 hour
P2	1 hour	1 business day	After 2 hours	After 1 business day
P3	4 business hours	3 business days	After 1 business day	After 3 business days
P4	1 business day	5 business days	After 3 business days	After 5 business days

17.3 How to Escalate Your Own Ticket

If your issue is not progressing:

1. **Reply to the ticket** stating the business impact and urgency (e.g., "client demo at 2 PM").
2. **Call the Service Desk** (option 1) and quote the ticket number to request an escalation.
3. If the SLA has been **missed**, email **it-escalations@meridianharbor.example** with your ticket number.
4. For ongoing unresolved issues, your manager can contact the **IT Service Manager**.

17.4 Escalation Contacts

Level	Role	Contact	When to use
1	Service Desk	1-800-555-0142, opt. 1	First contact
2	Service Desk Team Lead	it-escalations@meridianharbor.example	SLA missed, unresolved after Tier 1
3	IT Service Manager	itservicemanager@meridianharbor.example	Repeated failures, business-critical impact
4	Director of IT Operations	via IT Service Manager	Major outages, cross-department impacts
Security	SOC / CISO office	1-800-555-0142, opt. 2 / security@meridianharbor.example	Any security concern

17.5 Planned Maintenance and Outages

- Planned maintenance is announced at least **3 business days** in advance via email and #it-status.
- Standard maintenance window: **Saturday 10:00 PM – Sunday 4:00 AM Eastern Time**.
- Check **status.meridianharbor.example** or the Slack channel **#it-status** for live service status.
- Emergency maintenance may occur with less notice and will be announced immediately.

17.6 Feedback

After a ticket closes, you will get a short survey. Our target satisfaction score is 4.5 out of 5. Feedback can be sent to it-feedback@meridianharbor.example.

18. Exceptions

18.1 When Exceptions Are Possible

Where a business need cannot be met within this handbook, you may request a **temporary exception**. Examples: a developer needing a specialized tool, a researcher requiring a USB drive, or a contractor needing access beyond the standard.

18.2 Exception Process

1. Submit an **Exception Request** in HarborDesk (*Security* → *Policy Exception*) including:
 - Which policy and section
 - Business justification and impact if declined
 - Risks and **compensating controls** (e.g., extra monitoring, encryption)
 - Duration needed
2. Your **director** approves the business need.
3. **IT Security** assesses the risk (5 business days).
4. The **CISO** gives final approval for medium and high-risk exceptions. Critical-risk exceptions need CIO sign-off too.
5. IT records the exception in the risk register and implements the controls.

18.3 Terms

Item	Rule
Maximum duration	90 days
Renewal	One renewal of 90 days with fresh review; after that, a permanent change to policy or architecture is required
Decision time	Within 7 business days (urgent requests: 2 business days if approved by a VP)
Documentation	All exceptions are logged and audited quarterly
Revocation	IT may revoke an exception at any time if risk changes

18.4 Rules That Cannot Be Waived

No exception can be granted for:

- Disabling MFA for any account
- Disabling full-disk encryption or HarborShield on Company devices
- Sharing credentials between individuals
- Storing Restricted data on personal devices or personal cloud accounts
- Bypassing legal, regulatory, or contractual requirements
- Delaying incident reporting

18.5 Unauthorized Exceptions

Bypassing a control without an approved exception is a policy violation, even if the intent was business-driven.

19. Document Information

Item	Detail
Document title	Meridian Harbor Technologies, Inc. — IT and Information Security Handbook (2026)
Document owner	Chief Information Security Officer (CISO), with the Director of IT Operations
Approved by	Chief Information Officer and Chief Executive Officer
Version	2026.1
Effective date	February 10, 2026
Review cycle	Annually (next review due by February 2027), or sooner after major incidents or regulatory change
Applies to	All employees, contractors, interns, and third parties with access to Company systems
Related documents	Acceptable Use Agreement; Data Classification Standard; Incident Response Plan; Business Continuity Plan; Secure Development Standard; Privacy Policy; Code of Conduct
Questions about this handbook	it-policy@meridianharbor.example

Revision History

Version	Date	Summary of changes
2025.1	January 14, 2025	Prior annual edition
2025.2	August 5, 2025	Updated VPN client to HarborConnect; added AI tools guidance
2026.1	February 10, 2026	Annual refresh: MFA number matching required, HarborKey required for privileged users, SMS MFA removed, 12-hour VPN session limit, lost-device reporting window tightened to 1 hour

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